

Headline Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2026



You are a copy editor for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

Write the headline assigned for each of the given **six** stories. Use the following system: all upper and lower case letters, spaces, punctuation marks and symbols count as 1. Capitalize the first letter of the first word of each headline. You may use either upstyle (capitalizing the first letter of every word) or downstyle (capitalizing the first letter of the first word and the first letter of proper nouns only thereafter). Remember that main headlines belong on the top line and secondary headlines belong under the main headline. You have **30 minutes**. Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Story 1 — Write: 1-line headline counting 24-30

The school board will honor four yearbook staff photographers at its Thursday meeting after the staffers placed in the National Scholastic Press Association's Individual Awards Contest in November.

"It's really special to have even one photo place in NSPA's contest," yearbook adviser Carol Pulliam said. "To have four photographers place is so rewarding."

Senior Liz Chan earned first place Feature Photo and National Photojournalist of the Year at the awards ceremony at the fall national journalism convention.

"Since I was a finalist, I knew when they didn't call my name for second place that I would be named Photojournalist of the Year," Chan said. "It was such a rush."

Senior Mariana Ramirez earned first place News Photo. Senior Landry Ray earned second place Sports Photo, and junior Brandon Svevo won second place Feature Photo.

"It's not every day we can honor students who are the best in the country at what they do," Board President Amy Tate said. "The yearbook is always a source of pride for our district. These students are a big part of that."

Story 2 — Write: 2-line headline with each line counting 24-30

Students can compost some uneaten food waste during lunches beginning Monday after the Garden Club places new bins near the cafeteria exit.

The group plans to use the food waste as compost for their new garden project.

"We've been studying different veggies to determine what would be best to plant on campus," club president and senior Hema Satarasinghe said. "We've each been presenting weekly vegetables to plead their case for a spot in the garden. It's been fun to watch everyone argue for their chosen veggie like it's a real debate."

The group has built the space for the garden, and starting this spring, will plant zucchini, okra, tomatoes, onions and various herbs. The group plans to donate some to the school's culinary classes and the rest to the Leaguetown Food Pantry.

"We've done all the research, so I'd expect us to grow at least some edible veggies," junior Max Kapowski said. "Now we just need people to donate their uneaten lunch food to help us make it all a reality."

Story 3 — Write: 3-line headline with each line counting 20-26

As students prepare to complete their course requests for next school year, the district has announced a new Fundamentals of Artificial Intelligence class.

"Artificial intelligence is here," Principal Paul Prince said. "It's going to be part of our students' lives whether we like it or not. It's our responsibility to show as many students as we can how these systems work and how they should be used."

The semester-long course will offer lessons on data literacy, generative AI history and development as well as how to use AI responsibly.

"The class is a fantastic idea," computer science teacher Theresa Horvath said. "Students should know this stuff before they go to college or join the workforce."

Students will earn local elective credit for the class, which has no prerequisite.

"I use ChatGPT all the time, but I really have no idea how it works or if I'm using it the best way," sophomore Jaylee Cantrell said. "I know AI can make our lives easier, so I plan to get a head start by signing up."

Story 4 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 6-12 and 2-line secondary headline with each line counting 12-18

After losing her mother to cancer last year, everyone treated junior Tamika Dunsmore differently. Her friends. Her teachers. Her dad. That's when Dunsmore met senior Kayley Munoz, who had lost her mother in a car accident in 2019.

"I couldn't go home and tell my mom about my day anymore," Dunsmore said. "It's an emptiness that's hard to explain. No one else got it, except for Kayley."

After talking about their common history, the two started the first-ever Grief Club this year for students looking for support after experiencing the death of someone close to them. With 14 members, the group meets every Thursday afternoon and will travel to Disney World over spring break.

"It's cool that we have each other to talk to," Munoz said. "Our bond got very strong, very fast. Then we started thinking, 'What's something we could do together away from school?' Someone suggested Disney, and that's been our goal ever since."

The club's membership is open to anyone who wants to join.

"I know I'll never get over losing my mom," Dunsmore said. "But now I know I have a group of people who understand what I'm going through, and when I come to school, they'll be there going through the same thing."

Story 5 — Write: 1-line main headline counting 6-12 and a 1-line secondary headline counting 22-28

A deal's a deal.

Superintendent Maddy Clayton made one with high school students that if they could increase their attendance rate by two points during first semester, she would face her biggest fear: skydiving. Students met that challenge, increasing their fall attendance from 94% to 96%.

"This wasn't just some gag for fun," she said. "I'm deathly afraid of heights. Since schools in Texas are funded based on average daily attendance, I wanted to show students how serious I was about getting their attendance up first semester. I'm happy they actually came through, but I'm a little nervous to follow through with my end of the bargain."

Clayton's dive will take place Sunday morning. She plans to land in a field north of the high school.

"Most students never even see their superintendent," senior Ronald Brady said. "We see Ms. Clayton all the time. She visits our classes and walks around during lunch. I plan to be there when she lands, so I can give her a high five and congratulate her."

In addition to the skydiving promise, seniors earned a field trip to the Kimbell Art Museum in Fort Worth.

"We're lucky to have Ms. Clayton supporting our school and helping us get our attendance rate up," Principal Paul Prince said. "Let's hope for a nice soft landing so we can get back to work on this semester."

Story 6 — Write: 1-line headline counting 26-32

After the votes were counted, the student council announced Tuesday that the senior class has selected a beach theme for their May 9 prom. This was the first time the student group allowed seniors to vote on a prom theme.

"The beach theme seems a little casual for a formal dance, but when we decided to let students vote on a theme, we knew it may be something a little out of the ordinary," senior class President Clint Douthit said. "Traditionally, we've done themes like casino night or something having to do with Hollywood glamour. Maybe with a beach party theme I can wear my flip flops."

After a week-long nomination window, seniors had the option to vote for beach party, the Gilded Age, K-Pop, masquerade and Gatsby.

"Other than K-Pop, the rest of the themes seemed like well-worn territory," senior Lisa Aguilar said. "That's why I voted for the beach theme. I'm hoping maybe they can move it to the Leaguetown Beach Club or maybe bring in some tropical flowers or fruit. It could be really beautiful and fun."

Douthit said he's looking forward to moving past the voting process and planning the event.

"We definitely have our work cut out for us," he said. "I'm looking to go big. Maybe we can even bring some sand into the venue and have a beach volleyball tournament. Either way, you know we'll have to have a limbo contest. The planning starts now."

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Headline Writing Entry Sheet

All letters (upper and lower case), numbers, punctuation marks, symbols and spaces count as one (1). Place one letter or other unit in the appropriate spaces below. Remember to leave spaces between words. Note that the number of lines you are given on this sheet corresponds to the number of lines required for each headline. Write your number on the upper right-hand corner of this sheet.

■ Headline Number 1

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 2

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 3

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

■ Headline Number 4

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

_____ *main headline*

_____ *secondary headline*

■ Headline Number 5

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

_____ *main headline*

_____ *secondary headline*

■ Headline Number 6

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

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Headline Writing Contest Tips and Samples

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Headline writing is different than the other contests. It is suggested you pace yourself. You have about five minutes for each headline. Don't watch the clock, but be aware of the time you are taking to complete a headline. It is better to have four or five good headlines rather than six mediocre ones.
2. When writing the headline, first highlight or underline all the important words in the story. Then write a sentence based on those highlighted words.
3. After you have your first sentence, go back and begin editing out words. If you have a multi-line headline, separate the lines at a recommended area. This means you should not split phrases or ideas. Make sure all types of phrases — noun, verb, adverbial, adjective and prepositional phrases especially — are on the same line. Continue eliminating words until you get to a point where the headline fits. It may be necessary to re-write the headline one or more times or to take a different approach before you get the key idea. Remember to eliminate all unnecessary words such as article adjectives (a, an, the). In many cases a comma (,) can substitute for the word "and."
4. You may use a printed thesaurus or dictionary without any notes or markings inside. You may write in upstyle or downstyle.
5. Make sure you are within the prescribed count. Under no circumstances should you be under or over the maximum count. Judges are instructed not to consider any headline under or over the prescribed count.
6. Write headlines using active verbs in either present, future or present perfect tense. Follow the style of the headline. If it is a fun story, write a fun headline. If it is a serious story, write a serious headline.
7. Do not sacrifice accuracy for creativity or cuteness.
8. Normally, the main headline is used to grab the reader's attention. It is not necessary, although it is possible, to have a verb in the main headline when you have a secondary headline. The secondary headline should do one of two things: emphasize the significant aspects of the story or emphasize the unusual.
9. AP Style provides guidelines for headline writing. It is not required for contestants to follow AP Style, but a consistent style is recommended. Students may use a printed AP Stylebook (with no notes or markings inside) in the contest.

The following are additional basic headline rules for you to follow:

- avoid starting the headline with a verb
- use single quotes
- avoid using the same word twice in a headline
- avoid unfamiliar abbreviations
- do not end the headline with a period or exclamation point

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